Goals, Planning, Tracking

IT Product Development

Innopolis University, 2026

Agenda

- Discussion questions
- Goals
- Threshold of success
- Strategic planning
- Tactical planning

Goals

Discussion questions

What is a goal?

What are properties of unambiguous goals?

How to communicate goals to other people?

SMART goals

A goal is an idea of the future or desired result that people envision, plan, and commit to achieve.“ - Goal on Wiki

The **SMART** goal format lets you state goals precisely so that others can agree on what success wrt. this goal is and later tell whether it was achieved.

SMART goal:

- **S**pecific: what exactly will be done, and for whom?
- **M**easurable: what evidence or number proves it is done?
- **A**chievable: can we reach it with our skills, time, and resources?
- **R**elevant: does it align well with the project vision?
- **T**ime-bound: by when, with a date?

SMART goal example

Example

By the Week 3 soft deadline, October 15, 2026, our team ships a minimum usable product in which a user completes the core task chosen in Week 2 end to end, and the customer accepts it at that week’s meeting.

Properties

- **S**pecific — the MUP vertical slice for the core task, built only from Must Have stories.
- **M**easurable — the core task runs end to end, and the customer’s verdict is recorded as a DEC-nnn.
- **A**chievable — one course week, a 3–4 person team, using a candidate already reviewed in Week 2.
- **R**elevant — it is Submission 3 (7% of the grade) and the base for the Week 5 release.
- **T**ime-bound — October 15, 2026, 23:59 (soft), October 16, 2026, 23:59 (hard).

Quiz

Why write SMART goals?

Threshold of success (ToS)

Discussion questions

What is success?

What is failure?

What is between them?

Threshold of success (ToS)

Threshold of success:

Minimum set of SMART goals that must **all** be achieved for the project to be considered a success by the stakeholders.

If one of the goals is not achieved, the project will be considered a failure.

Why need it:

- Helps focus on essential goals
- Increases chances for a clear project success
- Helps communicate goals to stakeholders
- Helps identify the most important risks that are necessary to manage

ToS steps

1. Gather the whole team
2. Build a minimum picture of failure (when should the project be considered a failure, informally?)
3. List failure statements (testable - “We didn’t do X”, “We didn’t meet Y”, etc.)
4. Convert failure statements into success statements
   (testable - “We must do X”, “We must meet Y”, etc.)
5. Write a minimal set of SMART goals that cover the success statements

Guess the sequence of ToS steps

- Convert failure statements into success statements
- List failure statements
- Gather the whole team
- Write a minimal set of SMART goals that cover the success statements
- Build a minimum picture of failure

Discussion questions

What can be a failure statement for your team?

Planning

Discussion questions

What is planning?

Why do people plan?

When do people plan?

What types of planning do you know?

Planning types

Strategic

- Long-term
- Achieve global project goals
- Keep in mind the threshold of success

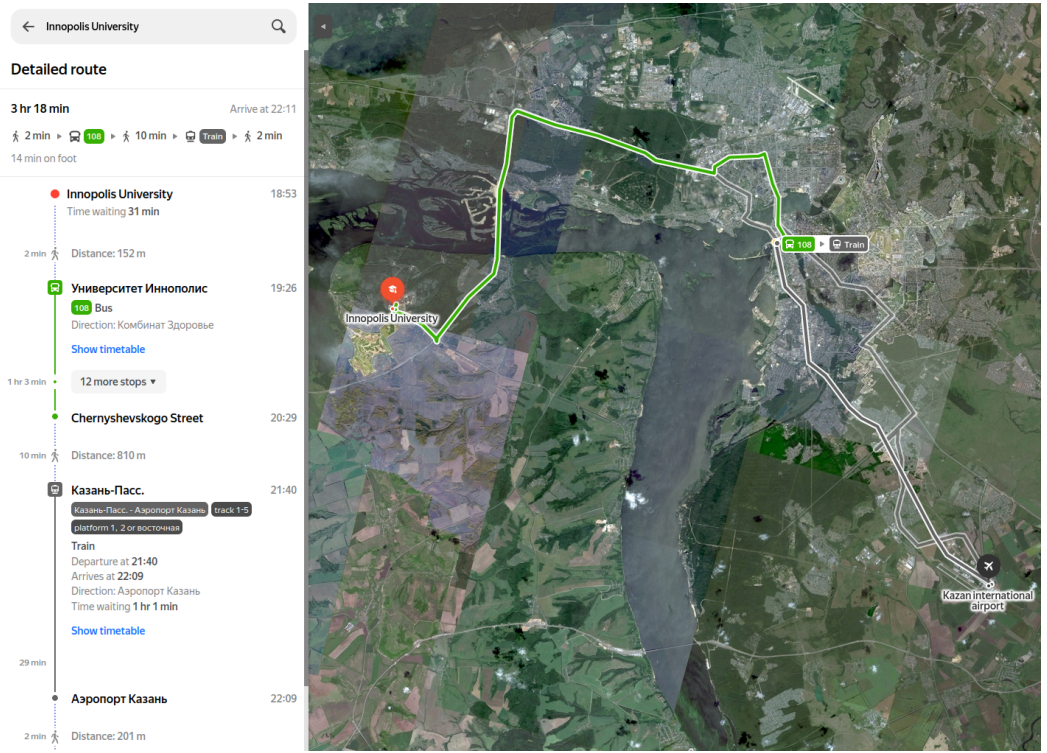
Tactical

- Short-term
- Achieve local project goals
- Complete tasks
- Situational

Strategic planning

Strategic plan example

A navigation app provides a strategic plan
- a path from start to finish.



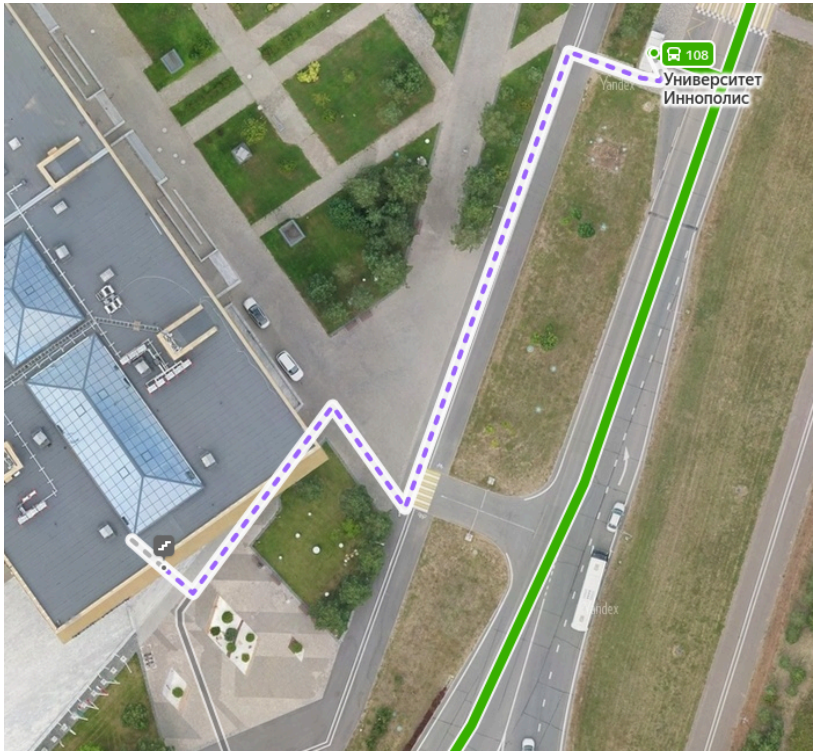
Strategic planning & tracking (level: global goals, sub-goals)

- **Define success wrt. your goals**
  - Make it testable (threshold of success)
  - Make sure all stakeholders agree (~80% of pain comes from skipping this step)
- **Develop a roadmap**
  - Decompose the path to success into steps (sub-goals, milestones)
  - Find a “zoom level” that works for your project
- **Monitor progress** - **“tracking”**
  - How much was done and how much remains?
  - Are we on track to complete promised deliverables?
  - Can stakeholders clearly see our progress?
- **Make contingency plans**
  - Define alternative solutions
  - Identify “point of no return” decisions
  - Identify risks

Tactical planning

Tactical planning example

The same navigation app provides
a tactical plan
- a step-by-step path to a local goal (sub-goal)
of the strategic plan



Tactical planning (level: local sub-goals and tasks)

- **Define who is responsible**
  - Every task has a specific person responsible for completing it (“responsible”)
- **Define when the work is done**
  - There is Definition of Done for the work (task, user story, etc.)
- **Review completed work**
  - There is a separate person who verifies that a task was done (“accountable”)
  - Iteration demo
  - What went wrong?
  - What went right?
- **Adjust to fix discovered problems**
  - What should we keep from what went right?
  - Which steps should we take to improve iterations?

Similar to The PDSA cycle

Quiz

What is strategic planning?

What is tactical planning?

What will happen if we ignore strategic planning?

What will happen if we lack tactical planning?

Questions?